



Midpoint Presentation

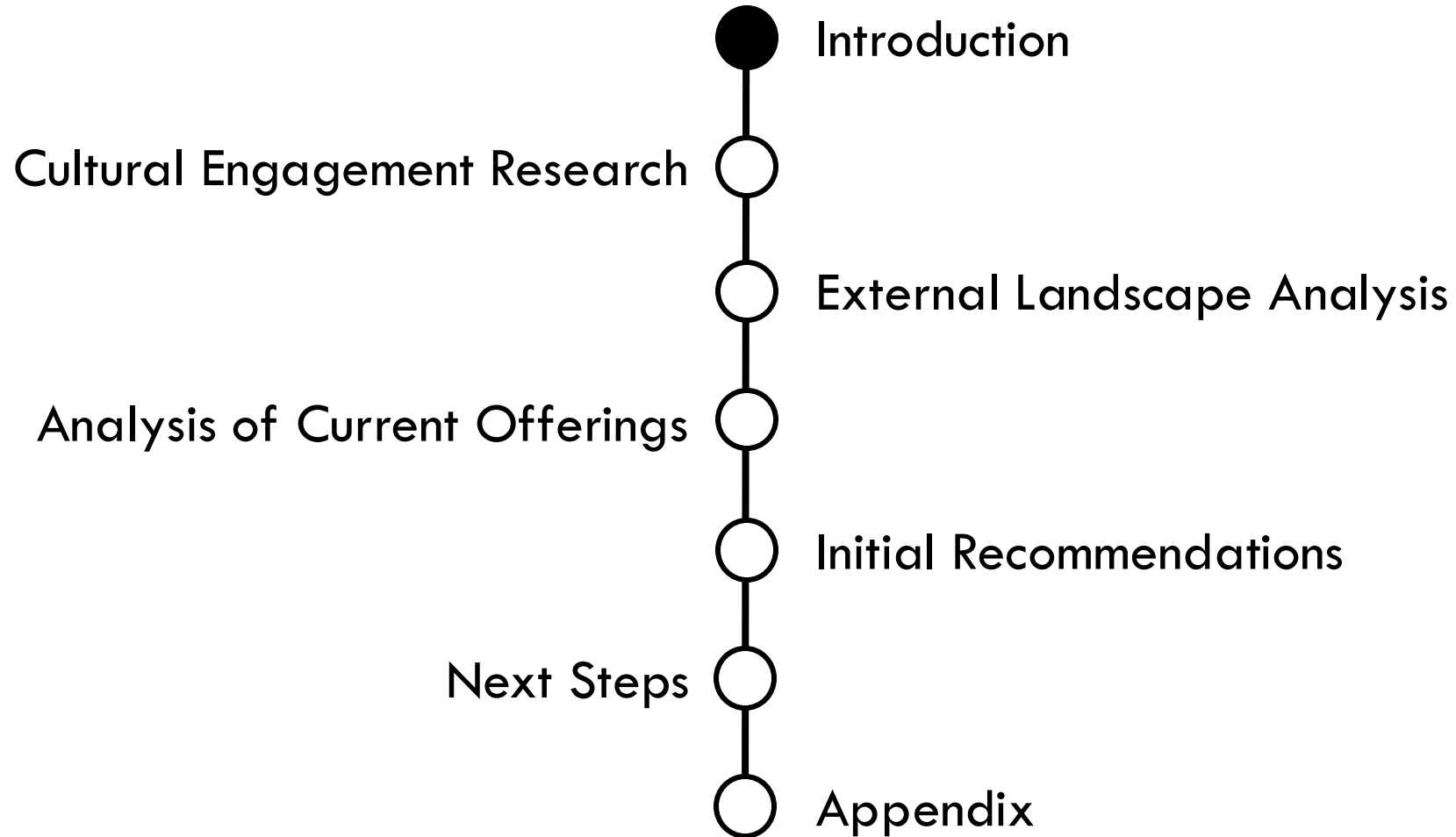
Spring 2025

Aarushi Shah | Azalea Bailey
Phoebe Anthony | Abhi Mukkamala | Zander Vaux | Emma Wang

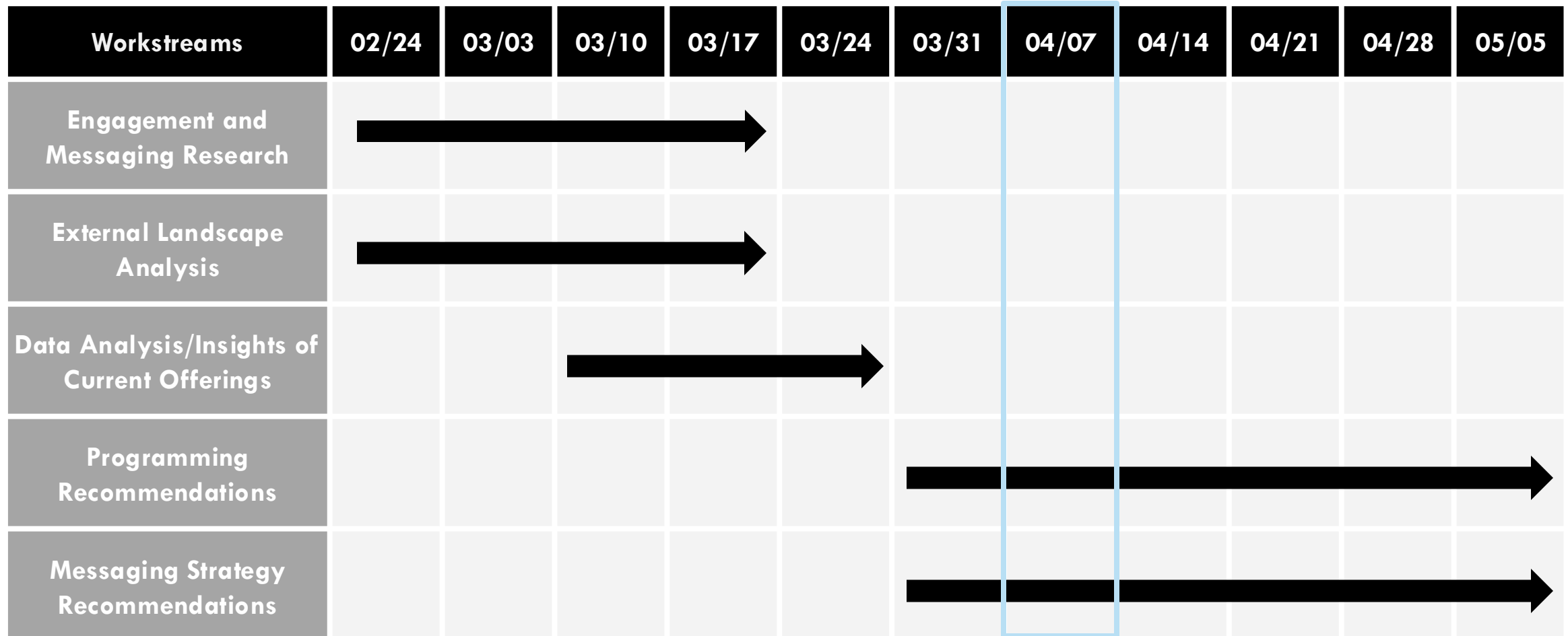
Presentation Agenda



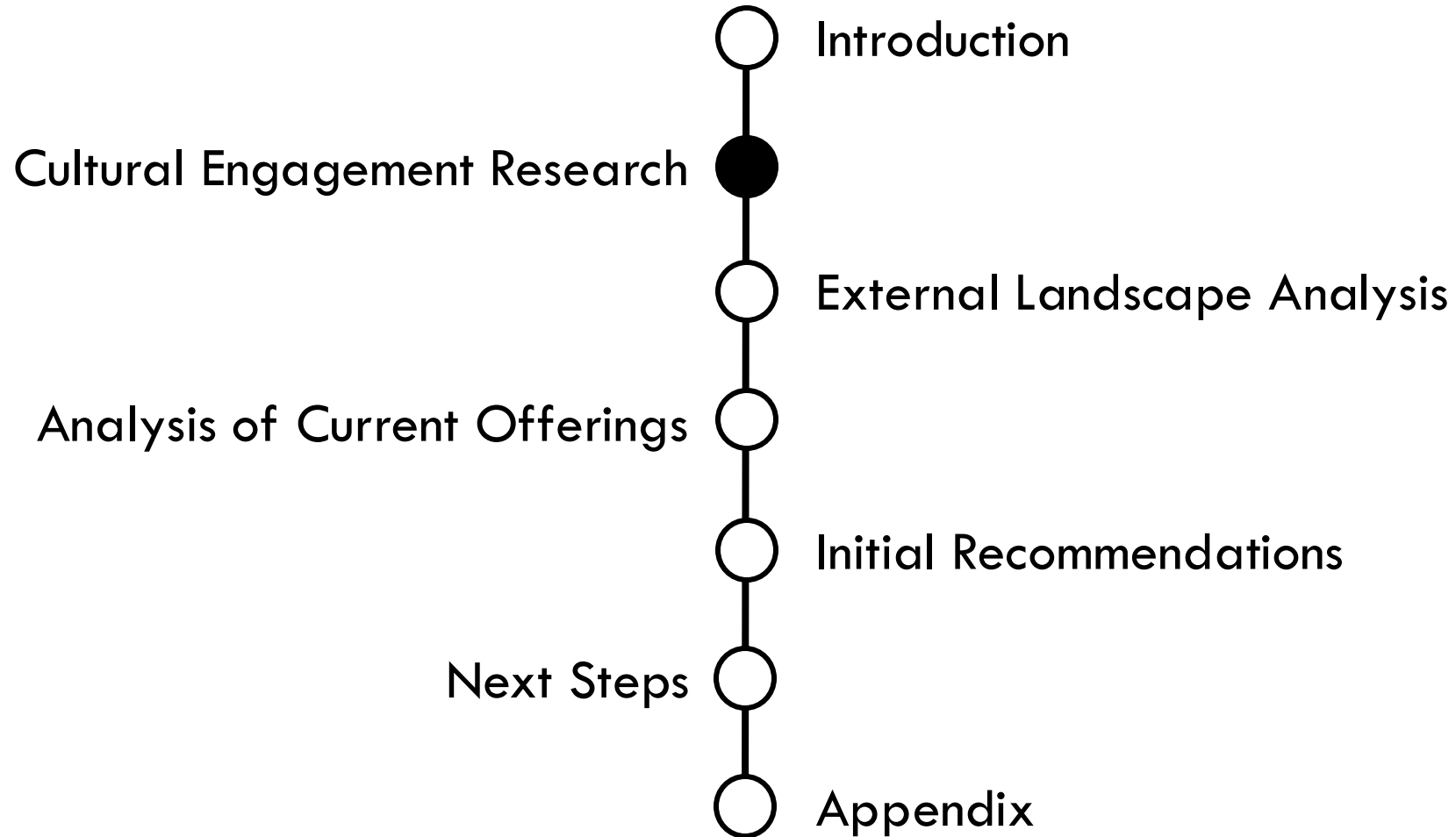
Presentation Agenda



We broke down the project into five key segments of work and created a week-by-week timeline to guide our recommendations



Presentation Agenda

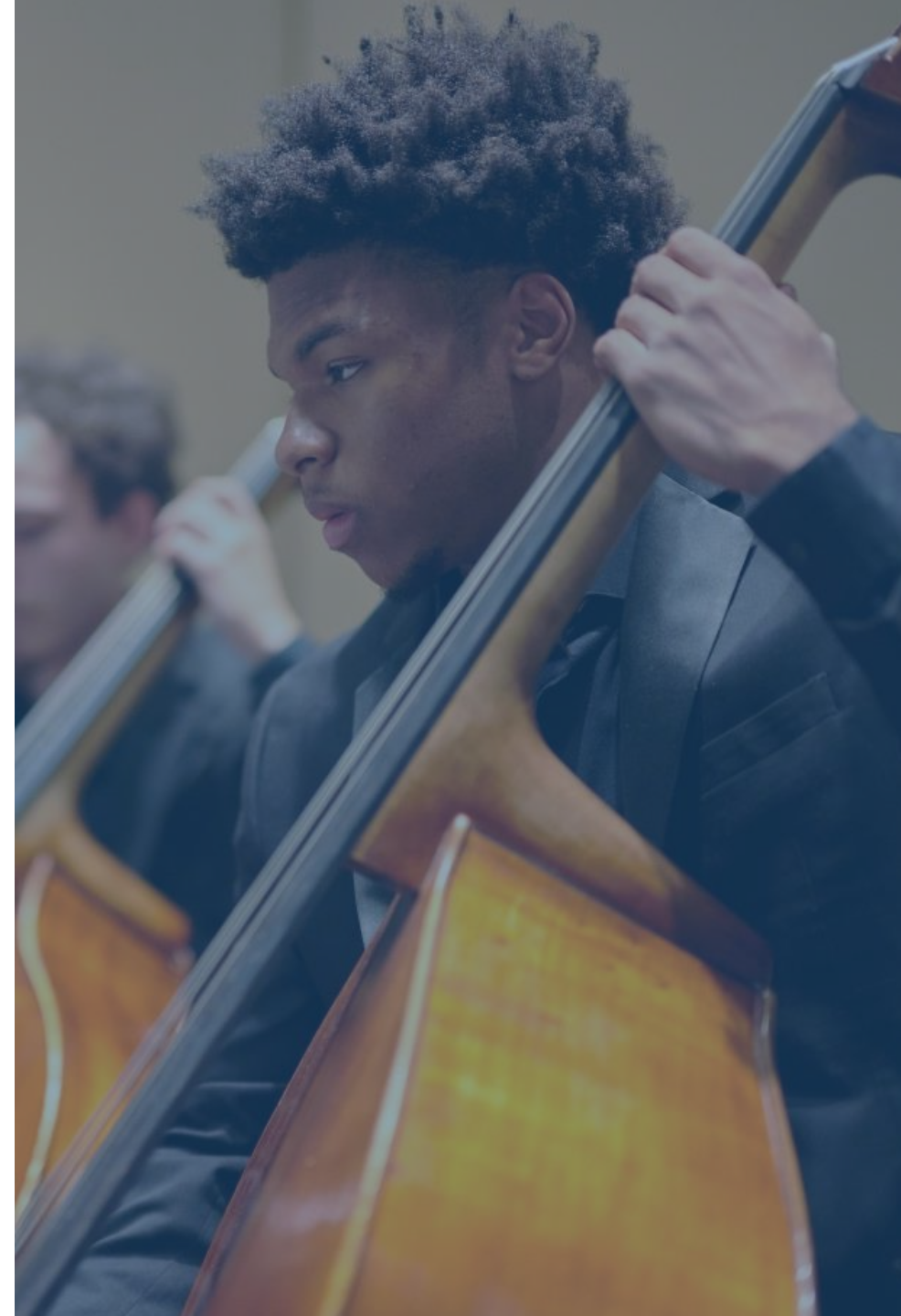


Research

Guiding Questions

What are the critical factors BSO must consider to ensure effective engagement through programming?

What are the best practices for devising messaging materials that will yield high engagement amongst various cultural/religious/affinity groups?



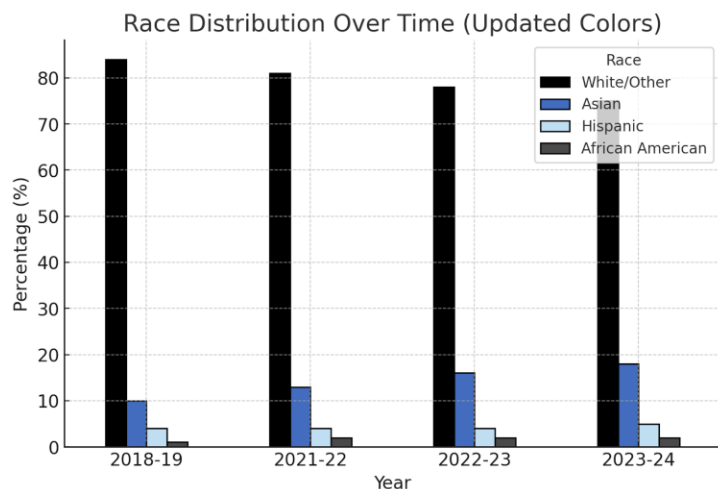
Leveraging cultural engagement is essential to maintain audience growth, local communities, and cultural connection

	Reflect Boston's Diversity	Representation & Belonging	Strategic Growth Potential
REASON	Boston's current demographics is over 50% non-White , BSO needs to evolve its programming to reflect and resonate with this diversity	Many communities don't see themselves in classical spaces , therefore, representation creates emotional connection and inclusion	BSO's traditional audiences are shrinking— cultural engagement will attract and retain a new, younger , and more diverse set of audiences
BENEFIT	Builds deeper community relevance by aligning with Boston's evolving cultural identity , fostering trust, visibility, and meaningful connection	Increases emotional connection, loyalty, attendance, satisfaction , and long-term engagement from historically underrepresented groups	Expands audience base, boosts ticket sales , deepens retention , and opens doors to new partnerships, sponsorships , and funding sources

Cultural engagement is **foundational**. To grow into the next generation and remain a **vital part** of Boston's **cultural landscape**, BSO needs to **align with the city's identity**, foster true belonging, and lead boldly with inclusive, **community-driven programming**.

Researching cultural engagement best practices will drive attendance and retention through programming and marketing

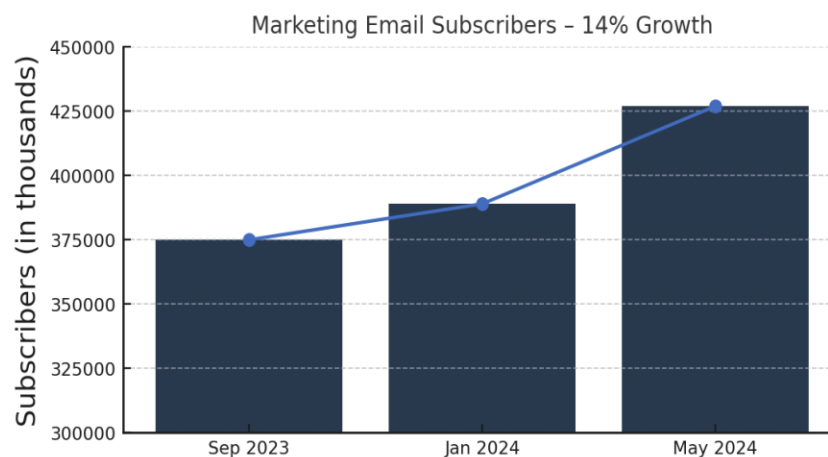
Race Distribution



Limited Diversity in Attendance

BSO's audience remains **predominantly White**, with **low representation from URM communities**. **Current programming may not resonate with these groups**, signaling a need for **more diverse performances, genre fusion concerts, or more casual performances**

Marketing Email Growth



Growing Digital Engagement

The **14% growth in email subscribers** indicates strong interest in BSO, but lack of in-person attendance suggests that **new audiences are not converting into concertgoers**, pointing to barriers like **relevance, accessibility, or concert formality**

Custom Subscription

CHOOSE YOUR OWN SUBSCRIPTIONS

Create a BSO experience that's uniquely yours, choosing any genre, any date, and any seating area in Symphony Hall.

As a Choose Your Own (CYO) Subscriber, you are entitled to exclusive subscriber benefits, including the flexibility to exchange your tickets for a different date at any time, for any reason.

Choose a minimum of three (3) concerts to become a CYO subscriber; your series cost will be calculated based on the number of concerts selected and the seating areas chosen.

Please note that for the 2024–2025 season, you may include Boston Pops concerts in this package, however Chamber Players concerts at Jordan Hall and Thursday morning rehearsals are not eligible for Choose Your Own Subscriptions.

Customizable Concert Experience

The **CYO model** provides a unique opportunity for BSO to let **audiences select concerts tailored to their preferences**—culturally diverse artists, genre-blending performances, or informal settings to **help break down the intimidation factor**

BSO can address gaps within its programs to better reflect Boston's diversity and strengthen audience engagement

INSIGHTS

Expand Representation

Compositions by **women** and **BIPOC composers** remain **significantly underrepresented** across all U.S. based orchestras

Community Partnerships

Current programs like the BEAM initiative focus on musicians, but audience-building **partnerships with communities remain low**

Concert Accessibility

Ticket prices have reached a "**breaking point**" for many, as cost and transportation remain **key barriers** for potential attendees

RECOMMENDATIONS

Partner with institutions like the **Sphinx Organization**, and collaborate with local artists to **blend classical and non-Western genres** (e.g., Haitian Kompa, Afro-Cuban jazz) and expand guest conducting roles for **emerging BIPOC and women artists**

Co-curate concerts with cultural organizations in **Nubian Square** and **Chinatown**, share revenues to **support local initiatives**, and launch a **BSO Youth Council** to advise on teen-focused programming, event design, and **community engagement**

Market the "**Card to Culture**" for **SNAP/EBT** cardholders, **partner with MBTA** to provide transportation, and host **neighborhood-based performances** with free admission and local guest artists to build familiarity and **reduce accessibility barriers**

BSO can learn valuable lessons from the success of Seattle Symphony's innovative *Untuxed* program series

Seattle Symphony: *Untuxed*



Untuxed is a relaxed, accessible concert format created to **attract new & younger audiences** via short, early evening concerts with no intermission in a casual setting where familiar, popular classical works are played (Vivaldi, Bernstein, Copland)

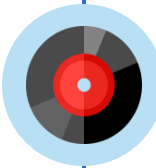
I. FORMAT & ENVIRONMENT



Relaxed concert structure increased first-time attendance, but lacked cultural markers that made the space feel **locally rooted**

Neutral design choices avoided alienation but also **failed to build strong personal** or community connection

II. REPERTOIRE & CONTENT



Audiences preferred **familiar, canonical works**, making Untuxed feel more traditional than progressive despite its casual tone

The absence of narrative left audiences as listeners, not participants in any **cultural conversation**

III. AUDIENCE ENGAGEMENT



Attendees treated Untuxed as a one-off event, with **minimal progression into deeper engagement** with the symphony

Audience demographics and feedback were collected, but rarely translated into visible **programmatic evolution**

Neighborhoods first by National Symphony Orchestra teaches us about local trust, cultural identity, and deep community presence



Culturally-Trusted Venues

Weeklong activations at trusted venues include **concerts, classes, and open rehearsals**, building **long-term presence** through culturally relevant programming—often featuring living composers like Florence Price or William Grant Still



Weeklong Immersive Activation

By performing in familiar, trusted spaces like **churches, nightclubs, and libraries**, NSO **eliminates barriers** of price, formality, and travel—bringing free, walkable cultural events to those unlikely to attend the Kennedy Center



Deep Local Collaboration

NSO collaborates with **schools, nonprofits, and local musicians** to transform audiences into co-creators; workshops and masterclasses in everyday spaces spark multigenerational visibility, connection, and cultural relevance

For a city as **diverse and neighborhood-driven** as Boston, cultural programming must localize—not generalize; the NSO shows that trust and turnout grow when concerts speak to the **identity of each neighborhood**, not the city at large.

NY Phil's mobile model allows for community-rooted, genre-bending performances in underrepresented neighborhoods



Program Overview

NY Phil Bandwagon was a pandemic-era initiative (2020–2021) by the New York Philharmonic to bring music directly to **underrepresented neighborhoods** across NYC

- Musicians performed on a **mobile stage mounted on a pickup truck**
- Concerts were **unannounced pop-ups** in parks, plazas, and street corners
- Featured **casual attire, genre-blending collaborations**, and local guest artists
- Aimed to **reach audiences unlikely to attend Lincoln Center**

What does it do?



Reimagines the concert format by going mobile—transforming a pickup truck into a pop-up stage and activating parks, plazas, and street corners with casual, genre-blending performances designed for high foot traffic and low intimidation



Bridges cultural gaps through hyperlocal partnerships—collaborating with neighborhood artists and showcasing youth composers to create performances that reflect, engage, and uplift the communities being served

50,000+

New Yorkers engaged through free pop-up performances in public spaces

30+

Neighborhoods across all five boroughs activated with live music

20+

Local artist partnerships, including Latin electronic and chamber ensembles

100+

Outdoor performances staged from a mobile pickup truck stage

How Tiered Digital Campaigns Helped the Dallas Symphony Orchestra Boost ROI and Improve Audience Engagement



How Tiered Digital Campaigns Helped the Dallas Symphony Orchestra Boost ROI and Improve Audience Engagement (cont)

STRATEGIES

- Use **Facebook and YouTube** to highlight DSO's brand story to increase **general brand awareness**
 - **KPI: Engagement on online campaigns**
-
- Delivered **engaging carousel ads** showcasing **current concerts** to users to boost reengagement
 - **KPI: Key page views (KPV) and ticket purchases**
-
- Retargeted recent site visitors and email clickers with **event-specific ads** and **urgency messaging**
 - **KPI: Number of Ticket Purchases**

FINDINGS

416K

Impressions per show from Tier 3 campaigns, building **broad brand awareness** across general audiences

540%

Average **return on investment (ROI)** for Tier 2 marketing campaigns targeting **moderately engaged ticket buyers**

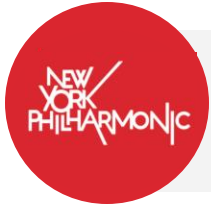
531%

Average ROI for Tier 1 urgency campaigns, focused on **high intent past purchasers** and **re-targeted loyal audiences**

By adopting a targeted, tiered messaging strategy like the Dallas Symphony Orchestra, BSO can effectively **attract new audiences**, **re-engage casual attendees**, and **deepen loyalty**—driving **higher ROI**, **community resonance**, and **sustainable audience growth**.

Case studies done by the League demonstrate best practices for orchestras in driving more inclusive and lasting engagement

IDENTIFIED STRENGTH



Young People's Concerts: Nationally televised live concerts, **introducing millions to classical music** through storytelling



Celebrate LA! A free, street festival with over 1,800 performers, highlighting the talent of **youth ensembles** and **BIPOC** artists



CSO Resound: **Grammy-winning** in-house label distributing recordings of live concerts to **global digital and physical audiences**

RECOMMENDATION

Launch a **youth concert series** at Symphony Hall and local schools with **Boston-specific stories and visuals** to **foster interest** in classical music and attendance

Host **neighborhood concerts** with that feature **BSO musicians, local Black, Latinx and Haitian artists**, working with cultural organizations to **expand reach**

Create a **BSO Digital Sessions**, capturing select live performances with short video profiles via YouTube, Instagram **bundling access with student tickets**

These models demonstrated musical experiences centering on **youth learning, audience identity, digital access**, can drive deeper loyalty and attract URM communities. BSO can build on these strategies to foster **deeper emotional connections and reach**.

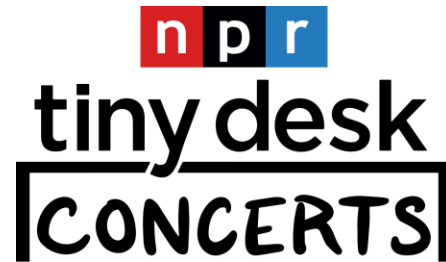
The BSO can also pull strategies from niche arts organizations that specialize in driving immersive and modern engagement



Cirque du Soleil

Revolutionized live performance by combining **theatrical storytelling**, **immersive staging**, and emotionally resonant design

Design select concerts with **visual storytelling elements** and experiment with local theater or dance groups



NPR's Tiny Desk

Built a **digital audience** through **intimate**, minimalist concerts filmed in **casual settings**, optimized for digital content and social media

Film **casual performances** for Reels/TikTok such as **behind-the-scenes** or "**Tiny Podium Series**" for younger audiences



The Shed

Blends disciplines (music, visual arts, and tech) and partners with modern artists to create bold, innovative, and collaborative experiences

Partner with **ICA Boston** or **MassArt** to co-curate visual installations to create **immersive museum experiences** tied to performances

Our research reveals actionable levers to expand cultural engagement, diversify audiences, and reduce access to barriers



CREATE VALUE

Identify high-potential programs and partnerships that resonate with underrepresented audiences, unlocking new attendance growth through genre-fusion, neighborhood outreach, and co-curated events



ENGAGEMENT

Pinpoint gaps between digital interest and in-person attendance to better target programming, pricing, and venue format, ensuring community relevance within cultural hubs



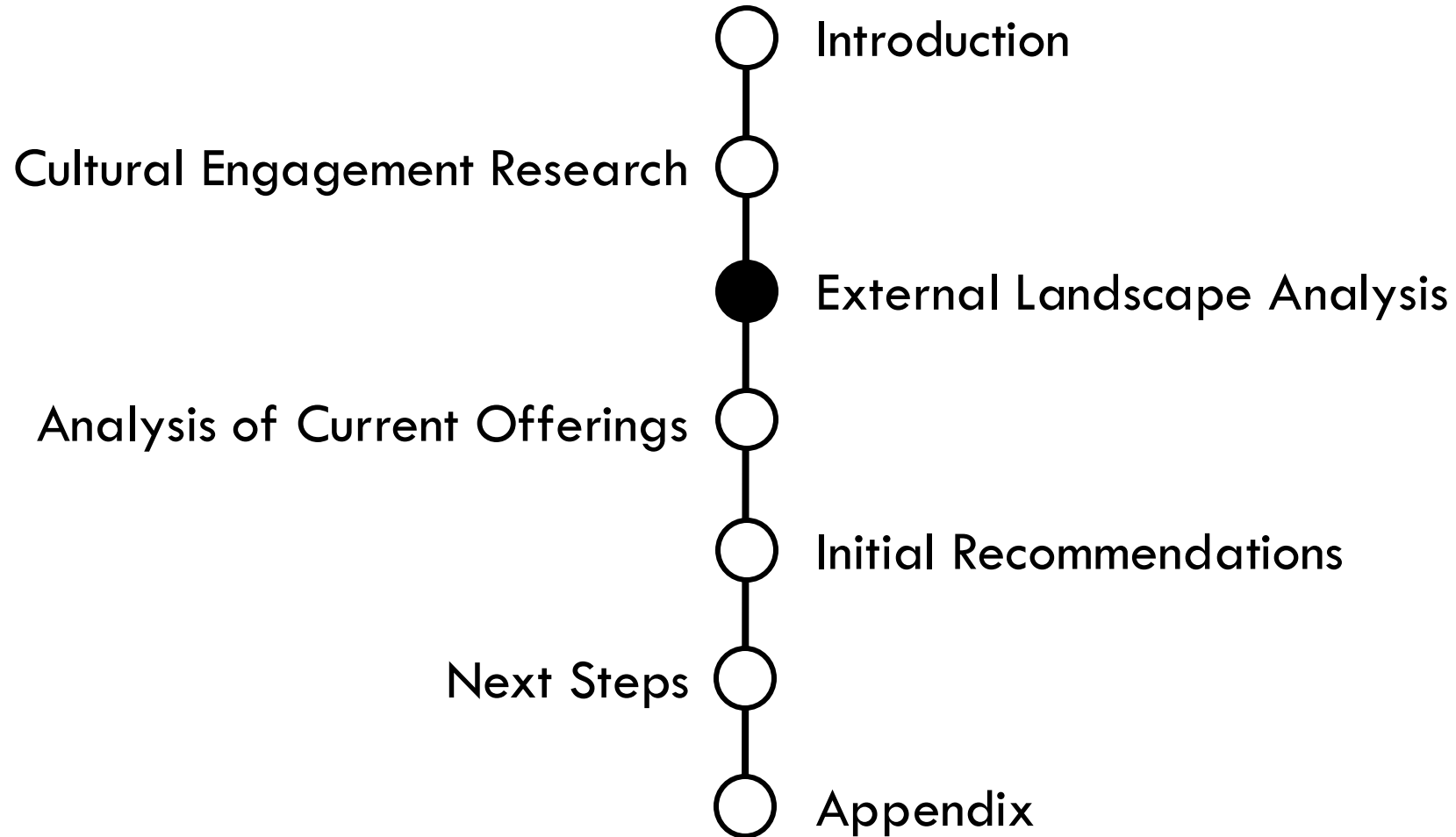
COMMUNICATION

Reframe how value is communicated by using clear, inclusive, and compelling language that shifts perceptions, demystifies the concert experience, and turns passive interest into active participation



True cultural engagement isn't achieved through outreach alone, it demands **structural innovation** in **format, venue, and curation** to dismantle perception barriers and generate sustained, measurable audience growth

Presentation Agenda



Landscape

Guiding Questions

How does our research align with external organizations' approaches to cultural engagement strategies?

What are the key considerations for organizations when devising new programs and marketing existing/new programs to diverse audiences?



While interviewing external organizations, we asked about audience demographics and successful engagement strategies

TOPICS



AUDIENCE DEMOGRAPHICS

Goal: understand makeup of **current** and **prospective audiences**



MARKETING TACTICS

Goal: learn successful ways to reach and **market to diverse communities**



ENGAGEMENT STRATEGIES

Goal: identify best practices in **cultural** and **community engagement**

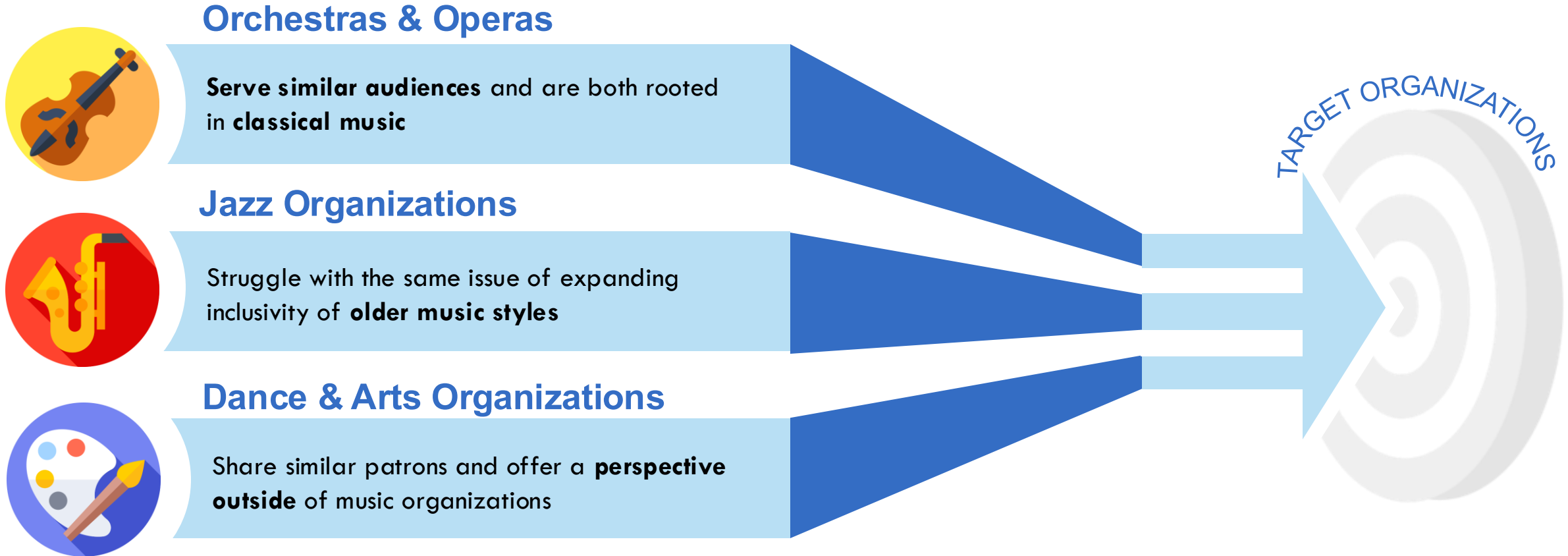
EXAMPLE QUESTIONS

What communities typically have the **highest engagement**? What communities are you **hoping to reach**?

How do you **tailor outreach to resonate** with communities?
Is there anything you found that **helps market to them**?

Has there been an **audience change** after implementation?
What helped **expand engagement**? What **hindered it**?

We interviewed an array of performing arts organizations around the nation to learn about their cultural engagement initiatives



General arts organizations face common challenges regarding marketing their events towards diverse demographic audiences



Limited relevance to younger audiences

Many programs are **tailored to older, traditional audiences**, which can feel disconnected from younger generation interests

Promote concert wording like “no prior music knowledge required,” or “**open to all**” to make it more approachable



High ticket prices that exclude college students

The cost of tickets can be **prohibitive** for college students and young professionals who have **limited disposable income**

To offer affordable ticket options, promote student passes and potentially **pay-what-you-can** options for select performances



Lack of engaging digital outreach and content

Younger audiences are highly active on digital platforms; there are **opportunities for improving BSO's online presence**

Create interactive **digital content** such as **behind-the-scenes**, **composer Q&As**, or even virtual reality (VR) experiences

By addressing the **unique needs and interests** of college students and young professionals, BSO can overcome these common challenges and **attract new audiences to foster a lifelong appreciation** for classical music in younger generations.

BSO can employ a diverse set of programming strategies to increase accessibility and welcome new, diverse audiences

Covers



Programming **well-known pieces** such as orchestral arrangements of popular songs or icons, film scores, or reimagined classic rock hits attract broader audiences and **lower barriers to entry** for new attendees

Demographics



Aligning **programming with community demographics** targets specific audience segments through **collaborations with affinity groups** or hosting bilingual or culturally themed performances such as Latinx Heritage Night

Outdoors



Organizations that expand programming beyond concert halls, **utilizing parks, community spaces, and plazas** such as a “BSO in the Garden” event make performances more accessible and **successful post pandemic**

By integrating these three strategies of **leveraging familiar music**, tailoring programs to **specific demographic** groups, and **expanding into outdoor** and non-traditional venues, BSO can increase accessibility and attendance.

BSO can expand interest in their events through new strategies for marketing to reach and retain diverse demographics

Language



Use language that is **inclusive, culturally relevant, and accessible**, such as translating marketing materials into multiple languages and using inviting language **free of terminology** such as event titles that reflect cultural celebration

Presentation



Using imagery and wording that **authentically reflect the communities** intended to reach; for example, featuring diverse performers and audience members and **relatable expressions** with photos of attendees

Tabling



Engage directly with college students through **on-campus tabling, student ambassador programs**, and outreach for **ticket incentives** and partnerships with students such as giveaways and music club or class collaborations

To broaden audience reach and deepen engagement with key demographic groups, BSO should **ensure that they are using inclusive marketing language**, strong **authentic and engaging visuals** and prioritize **in-person interactions**.

We asked organizations about how they responded to post-pandemic operations and how that impacted engagement

The Met
ropolitan
Opera

“We do a lot of testimonials to ask audiences after concerts... said they didn’t expect others to look like them.”

- M. Milton; *The Metropolitan Opera*

Chicago
Humanities

“We now run the same show multiple times if it’s a popular one instead of a one night one time event.”

- K. O’Reilly; *Chicago Humanities*



“We had to think about DSO’s place in the community... We now host neighborhood initiative events.”

- C. Valenti; *Detroit Symphony Orchestra*

I. REPRESENTATION

Audience members are so used to **not seeing diversity reflected in the audience** that they are surprised when there is; to foster inclusivity, BSO could **promote representation in marketing materials and community engagement**

II. FLEXIBILITY

Repeating successful shows instead of limiting them to one-time events can increase accessibility and allows for broader audience reach. This can also help **build familiarity and demand while maximizing impact** of high-interest concerts

III. COMMUNITY

Orchestras and arts organizations must **reassess their role within their communities first**; expanding into neighborhood-based initiatives and local outreach events **strengthens connections and deepens audience interest**

We asked organizations about their approach to cultural engagement and how they resonated with communities



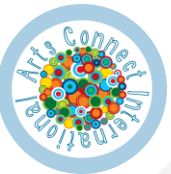
“It is crucial that members of the community lead. Our most successful event was led by an all-black advisory board.”

- L. Green; Seattle Symphony



“We send a few individuals to work in focus groups with communities to build deeper connections with individuals.”

- C. Valenti; Detroit Symphony Orchestra



“It is extremely helpful that our team is made up of those who can relate to the communities we reach out to.”

- M. Rose; Arts Connect International

1. COMMUNITY LED

The **people of the community** know the most about what their community needs, more so than anyone in the organization; it is necessary that cultural programming allows these voices to be at the **forefront of cultural event planning**

II. FOCUS GROUPS

Having **one or a few individuals** work with communities fosters a more **intimate relationship** of authenticity and trust; instead of approaching communities as an organization, approach them as an individual looking to learn more

III. SHARED IDENTITY

Those who are engaging with cultural groups should have some **shared identity or experience** with them to make communities feel more **comfortable and trusting** of BSO; show them that they are welcome in the organization

We asked organizations about their top methods that helped them expand engagement and interest with different communities

Chicago
Humanities

“Because we are a nomadic organization, we can go out into the city and host events in places we couldn’t normally.”

- K. O'Reilly; Chicago Humanities

NHSC
NEW HAVEN SYMPHONY ORCHESTRA

“We have free concert tickets available to students through the financial aid office and also run a shuttle bus to concerts.”

- E. Carroll; New Haven Symphony Orchestra

The Met
ropolitan
Opera

“Our next season showcases a piece on gun violence which brings together those impacted communities.”

- M. Milton; The Metropolitan Opera

I. MOBILITY

Bringing performances into communities rather than relying solely on traditional venues can reach broader and more diverse audiences; BSO could **host events in unconventional spaces to enhance accessibility for all different audiences**

II. INCLUSION

Providing **free or largely subsidized tickets and offering transportation solutions** such as shuttle services removes barriers to attendance, **particularly for students and lower income community members**

III. UNDERSTANDING

Utilizing contemporary programs to speak on **current social issues**, which focuses on representing not only cultural communities, but also **impacted communities** with shared experiences, fostering **a sense of community belonging**

We asked organizations what communities they were hoping to reach if they were trying to expand their audience demographic

DV
AV

“The communities we serve have many Spanish, Cantonese, and Vietnamese speakers, which we are trying navigate.”

- S. Connors; Da Vinci Art Alliance

I. LANGUAGE

Looking at the **primary languages spoken** in Boston and the surrounding suburbs will help to identify target communities and provide insight on how to better engage with them **using non-English languages in outreach and marketing efforts**

PHIL
NY
NY
PHIL

“As New York’s orchestra, our audience extends past ticket buyers—broadcasts in Geffen Hall are free to anybody.”

- U. Oneyeukwu; New York Philharmonic

II. ALL-INCLUSIVE

Free live, in-person broadcasts of ongoing orchestral events at performance venues such as Symphony Hall will make all people of Boston, regardless of ticket purchase, feel like they are a part of the **BSO community**

THE
CLEVELAND
ORCHESTRA

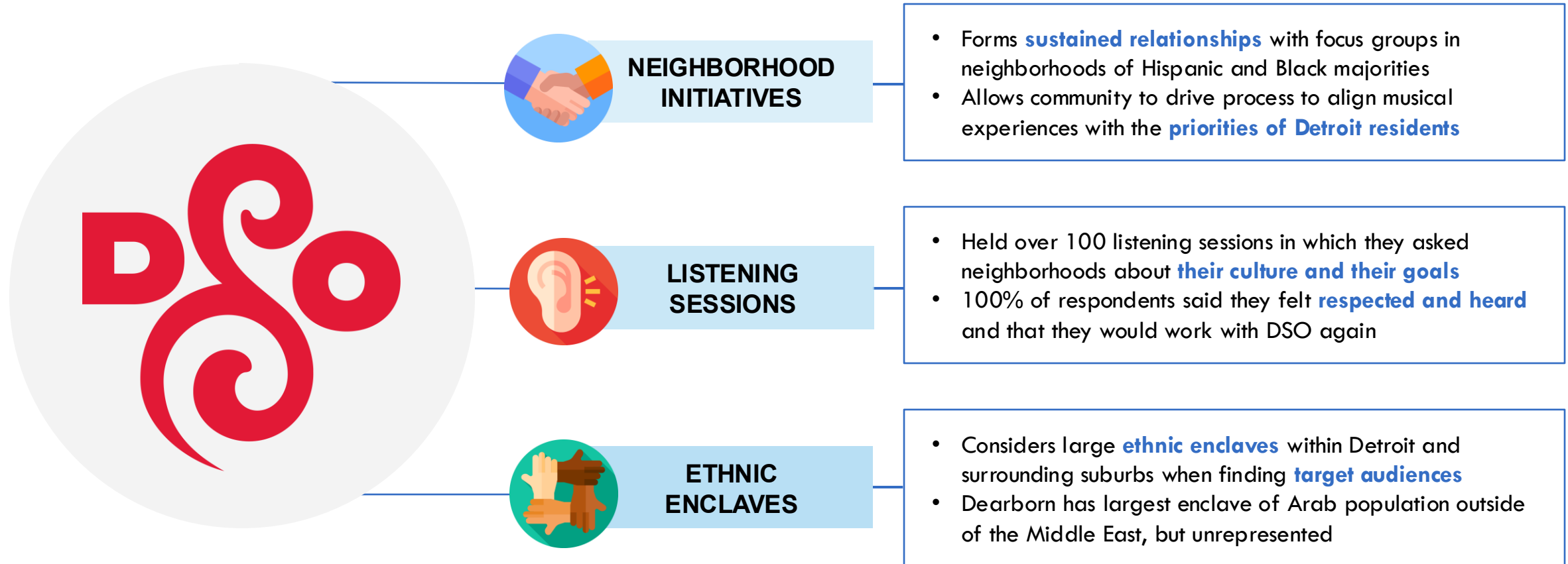
“Gospel concerts are a one of the ways we uphold our commitment to the black community of Cleveland.”

- T. Webb; Cleveland Orchestra

III. RELIGION

Holding orchestra events that **cater to both religious and cultural communities** will attract a more diverse audience, as both members of the religious group and the cultural group will find the program engaging

Our interview with the Detroit Symphony Orchestra revealed their successful strategies in reaching cultural communities



Our external benchmarking aligns with our case studies, yielding strategies for increased engagement with new demographics



RESEARCH

BENCHMARKING

METHODOLOGY

1

Development of **high-potential programs, partnerships, and events** allows for connection with **new audiences** to be reached

Listening to community needs starts **with surveys and adapting programming accordingly**, allowing their voices to be heard

Ensure representative community **data survey collection** to design new events that resonate with **target cultural demographics**

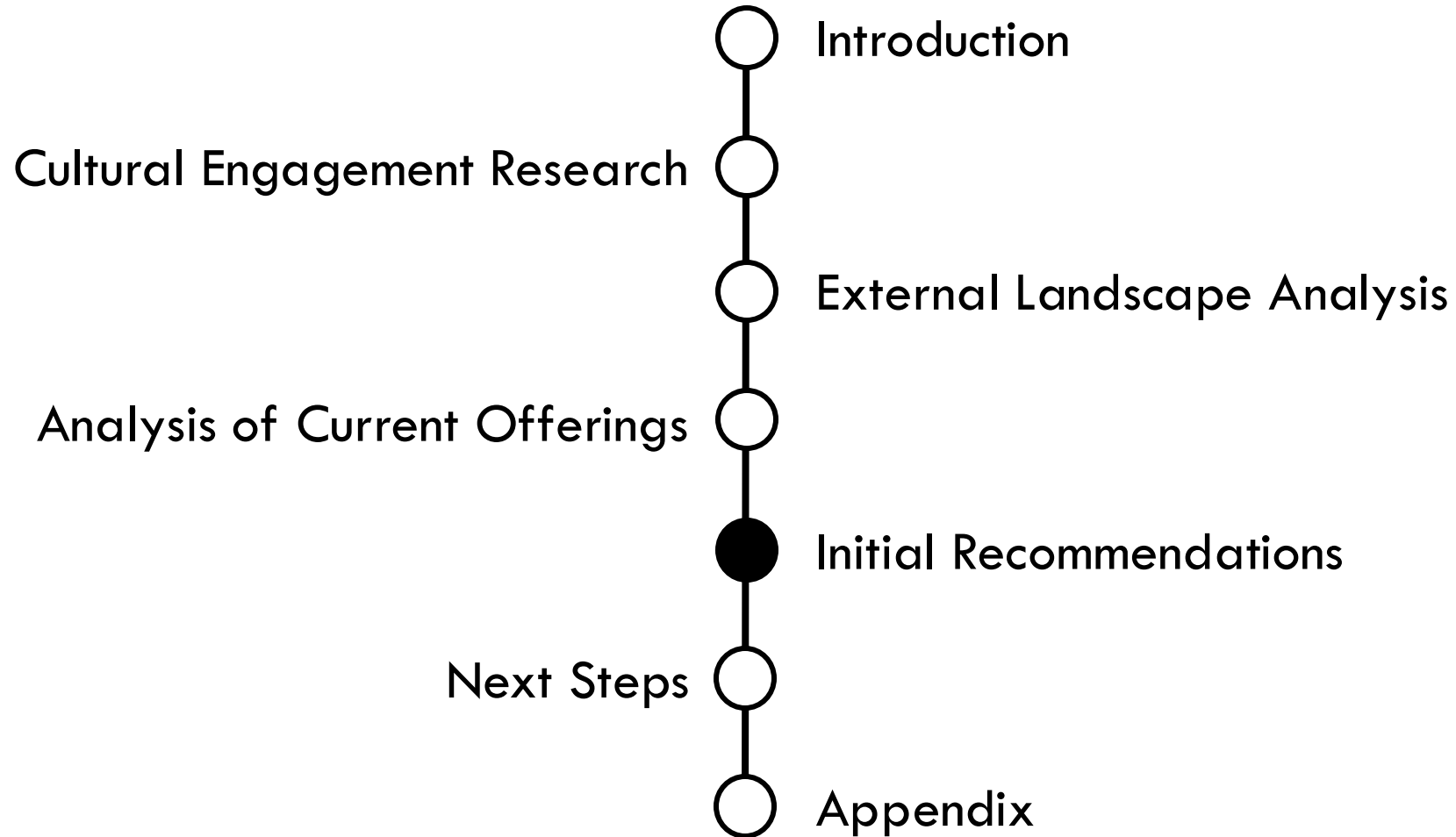
2

To **address barriers in attendance**, having casual, mobile, or customizable concert formats will **allow for flexibility**

Identify primary languages and **translate key promotional and marketing** materials into those languages to extend accessibility

Translate marketing materials into primary community languages to **optimize language accessibility** and engagement

Presentation Agenda



Recommendations

Guiding Questions

What strategies can BSO implement to bridge identified gaps in marketing and programming?

How do these strategies align with established best practices in community and cultural engagement?



Increasing language accessibility in marketing efforts will expand reach to a larger demographic of different ethnicities



Case Study

DVAA has identified Spanish, Cantonese, and Vietnamese as **primary languages spoken** in their region and are in the process of accommodating non-English speaking communities

Implementation

Translate event descriptions online and on physical brochures to increase accessibility and reach

Add **translations to YouTube videos** with spoken introductions that describe the concert or program

Add translations to descriptions to **Instagram posts** and on reels that have a spoken component

Measuring Impact

Measure **audience demographics** for the same event before and after increasing access to translations

Look at **ethnic demographics of interactions** to see if there is a measurable increase in diversity

Use data from **Instagram Account Insights** to measure changes in audience demographics

Increasing **language diversity in marketing** will draw in a larger audience of **non-English speakers**. To expand to these demographics, BSO should look at **prominent languages** in the region and incorporate them into marketing.

Incorporating new event language, visuals, and imagery that resonate with target audiences will engage diverse attendees

Chicago Humanities

Case Study

Boosted attendance by tailoring **event titles, descriptions, and visuals to resonate** with younger and BIPOC communities, using community-informed naming conventions

Implementation

Collaborate with community organizations to review drafts and finalize to ensure alignment

Create two or more versions of promotional content to track engagement differences with testing

Host a community listening session or **focus group to co-create names**, taglines or visual themes

Measuring Impact

Include **short post-event or post-ticket purchasing surveys** asking for feedback on marketing materials

Social media engagement such as **likes, shares, CTR, open rates, comments, and saves** on materials

Track sentiment and **attendance metrics** to see if attendees were influenced by updated branding

To **grow and diversify audience interest in events**, adopting a marketing strategy that is **focused on authentic representation and intentional design** will position BSO as a community-rooted organization.

Tabling with information about BSO at nearby colleges and hosting tables themselves will help forge cultural partnerships



Case Study

The Boston Jazz Foundation partners with the Berklee Institute of Jazz and Gender Justice in a festival that hosts **tables of different college organizations** at shows

Implementation

Utilize the **abundance of colleges** in the greater Boston area and **table with information** on campuses

Partner with **cultural music clubs** at colleges and table with them to reach a specific cultural group

Hold receptions before events that highlight **local cultural organizations** to increase **community partnership**

Measuring Impact

Track the **number of college-aged students buying tickets** after tabling sessions to gauge effectiveness

Look at **ticket sales of that specific cultural community** after tabling sessions with culturally affiliated clubs

Measure and **compare audience ethnic demographics** of events that have receptions with those that don't

BSO should **table at colleges** in the Boston area to increase reach as well as create **opportunities for partnerships** on campus. Hosting their own tables will further community engagement and cultural inclusivity.

Diversifying programming to include works representing diverse community groups creates a more dynamic experience



Case Study

NHSO **diversified offerings** by including more diverse works such as Black, Latinx, and Asian composers that **reflect the community backgrounds** and increased audience diversity

Implementation

Curate a season that **includes both iconic classical works** and newer contemporary pieces

Organize **community listening sessions** or open rehearsals to hear feedback on programming

Create composer or artist spotlights on social media and offer community programming for new voices

Measuring Impact

Tracking partnerships with **cultural organizations and engagement** with concert returning attendees

Audience surveys and post-event feedback forms to **provide data on demographics and insights**

Track **attendance for new diverse events** and analyze media pickup, social shares, and partnership growth

By **incorporating contemporary and well-known pieces in concerts and events**, BSO can attract a broader audience and ensure that the orchestra **remains accessible and relevant to all** while fostering appreciation for the arts.

Hosting free screenings of the orchestra in different Boston neighborhoods will draw in more diverse audiences

The Metropolitan Opera

Case Study

The Metropolitan Opera hosts **free screenings of operas** in parks across different New York City boroughs, attracting **thousands of viewers per night**

Implementation

Host **regular screening events** of different, diverse orchestra performances at **public parks**

Have a few **musicians attend screenings** and **play live music** to make the screening more engaging

Have **brochures** available with the current season's offerings to provide **easy access to event information**

Measuring Impact

Measure average **change in number of ticket sold** for performances held soon after the screening event

Track attendance at screenings without the live orchestra and compare to ones with live performers

Survey online ticket buyers to see where they heard of the event; measure rate of park attendees

Free screenings of the orchestra in **public areas like parks** are more accessible to those who can't attend live shows. BSO should host live screenings of performances to expose a larger community to the orchestra.

Reimagining orchestral belonging through campus-led cultural hubs to break down barriers of intimidation for live music events

Symphony Circles

BSO partners with to embed monthly, student-curated programs the **Boston-area colleges** at blend classical music with **open mics, storytelling, and cultural dialogue**—co-created by and for students

Designing Symphony Circles for College Audiences



Monthly **concerts themed around student identities** (e.g., Pride, Lunar New Year), co-curated with campus clubs and featuring BSO musicians, open mics, & storytelling

Rotating musicians embed on campus each semester via **teaching, mentoring, and performing** through casual pop-ups that make classical music approachable and ever-present



Each event **invites local orgs and student groups** to table, turning performances into lively **cultural fairs** that spark connection beyond the music

Track % of first-time attendees who return to a BSO concert, student orgs re-engaged per campus, **audience diversity lift vs. baseline**



To drive true cultural engagement, BSO should rethink how it **listens, collaborates, and shows up**—not just perform, but belong and resonate with its audiences.

Casual Concerts: Community-Curated Performances with Cultural Advisory Committees

Cultural Advisory Boards

BSO's casual concert series invites Boston's cultural leaders to co-curate one performance each season—collaborating on music, visuals, and experience design to reflect the communities they serve. These events are built with, not just marketed to, the audiences they celebrate

- Embeds **authentic representation** through co-creation, not top-down programming
- Builds lasting trust by **sharing creative control** with local cultural voices
- Grows audience diversity by positioning BSO as a **cultural collaborator**, not an outsider

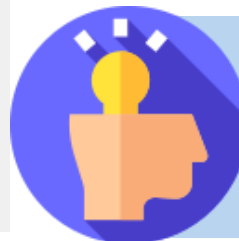
Each season features a casual concert co-designed by a Cultural Advisory Committee—**local nonprofit leaders, community artists, & creatives** shape the entire experience from theme to visuals

Community-forward **visuals**—like **bilingual programs, reels, and co-branded merch**—make the concert feel like a cultural event, not a formal performance



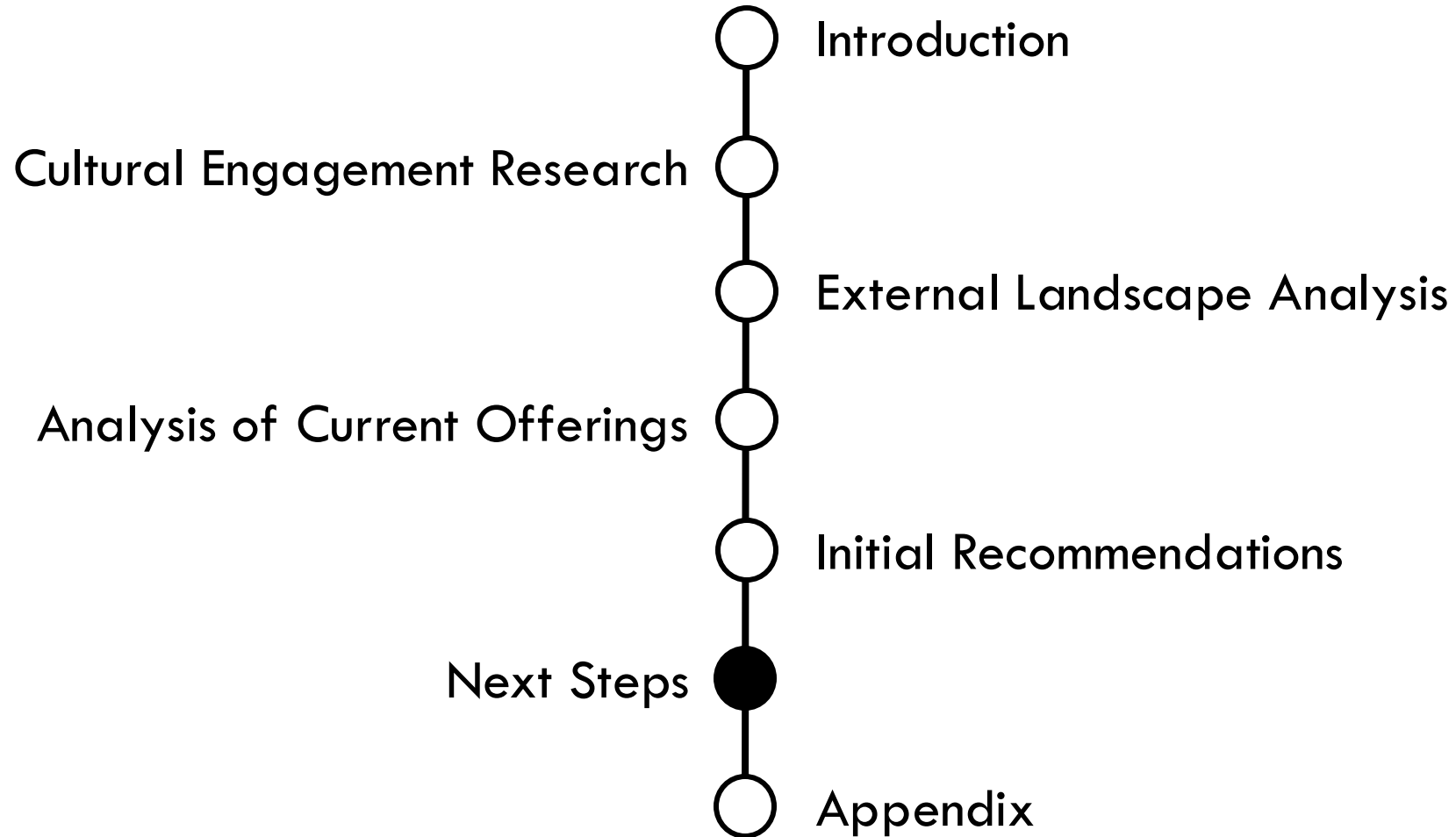
Food, visuals, & storytelling are aligned to the community advisors help select performers, design the vibe, and choose local vendors to make it feel like home

Track cultural self-identification and retention to measure long-term impact, not just ticket sales—informing DEI benchmarks and deepening audience trust



To create real cultural connection, BSO must co-create concerts that reflect how **communities gather, celebrate, and feel seen.**

Presentation Agenda



In the remaining five weeks of our engagement, we will develop a strategic playbook encompassing our recommendations

Programming



Case Studies

We will supplement recommendations surrounding the improvement of existing programs or new programs altogether with relevant case studies from similar organizations that provide a foundation for our programming recommendations



Customer Insights

We will provide the BSO with an in-depth analysis of their current customers, including demographic and retention analyses to guide our programming recommendations, and will supplement each recommendation with 2 user stories

Marketing/Messaging



Implementation Tactics

In addition to providing strategies and reworkings of tailored advertising materials and unbiased wording, we will provide specific insights into where and how BSO can use our recommendations for effective implementation



Projected Impact

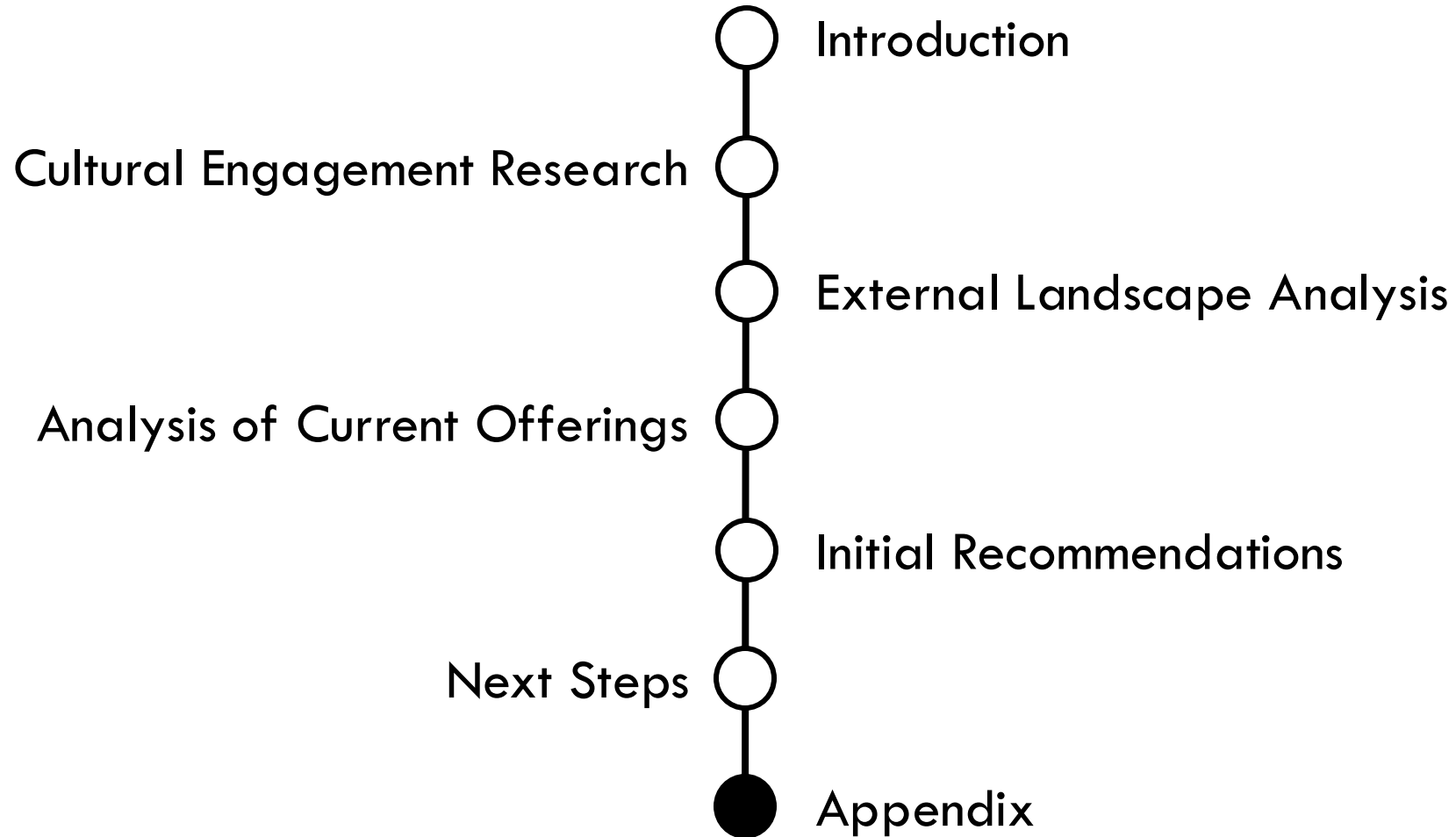
We will provide BSO with an estimate on the resources and impact of each strategy, including changes in audience demographic and participation, audience retention rates, and satisfaction with the BSO's cultural engagement initiatives

The Berkeley Group will assist the BSO in increasing **ticket sales and engagement from key Boston demographics** by identifying gaps in current messaging/offerings and **providing recommendations to target key cultural groups**.



Thank you for listening! Questions?

Presentation Agenda



Review: “League of American Orchestras”

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Artistic Planning

	Community-Centered	Flexible Pricing	Youth Involvement
Observations	- Featuring diverse composers and musicians fosters inclusivity and stronger connections - Orchestras that integrate culturally relevant programming see higher engagement	- High ticket prices often prevent lower income groups from attending any concerts - Discounted or free tickets encourage participation from underrepresented communities	- Interactive and hands-on activities create more memorable experiences - Engaging with youth in planning of events fosters stronger participation
Insights	BSO should curate performances featuring underrepresented artists to build stronger connections	BSO should expand affordability, including community discounts & free events, for more accessibility	BSO should establish youth panels and interactive workshops to make concerts more engaging

Review: “Collage Group”

7-Step Guide to Create An Engaging Multicultural Marketing Strategy

	Cultural Messaging	Multilingual Marketing	Community Partnerships
Observations	• Culturally informed messaging strengthens connections with diverse audience segments • Generic marketing fails to create connections and catch attention of different cultures	• Multilingual marketing expands accessibility for non-English speaking communities • Translating key materials improves engagement, connection and builds trust	• Community partnerships enhance audience trust and overall long-term engagement • Local organizations help orchestras market and reach completely new cultural groups
Insights	BSO should develop culturally nuanced marketing that represent different audience groups	BSO should offer multilingual outreach to connect with Boston’s non-English speaking communities	BSO should collaborate with cultural organizations to create different cultural programs

Review: “Association Européenne des Conservatoires”

Audience engagement and development strategy

	Early Exposure	Interactive Formats	Rebranding Music
Observations	• Early exposure to classical music to students increases their engagement for life • School based programs would cultivate the future audiences of different musical concerts	• Traditional concert settings generally are reported as intimidating to new audiences • Informal and interactive formats of music enhances accessibility and improves audience comfort	• The perceived elitism in classical music and concerts deters diverse audiences • Inclusive branding makes orchestras feel more approachable and relevant
Insights	BSO should expand to school programs to introduce young students to classical music	BSO should experiment with relaxed concert settings to make the environment more welcoming	BSO should rebrand some performances to a more casual tone for more diverse audiences

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Review: “Chamber Music America”

Audience Engagement: Research & Resources

	Audience-Specifics	Interaction & Engagement	Cultural Representation
Observations	• One-size-fits-all engagement models generally fails with reaching out for diversity • Tailored outreach strategies, although require more effort, create deeper connections	• Audiences report that they feel more connected when concerts foster some social interactions • Pre- and post-concert discussions strengthen relationships and engagement	• Cultural representation in the programming itself attracts broader community interest • Heritage-themed concerts can increase audience interest, attendance, and loyalty
Insights	BSO should design audience specific engagement strategies representing cultural/social values	BSO should incorporate discussion questions or sessions to enhance audience connection and retention	BSO should develop an annual cultural music event to celebrate Boston’s diverse communities.

Review: “[NewMusicUSA](#)”

Audience Engagement: Research & Resources

	Cross-Cultural	Interactive Concerts	Expanding Repertoire
Observations	• Cross-cultural collaborations introduce new musical perspectives and styles • Cultural fusion concerts attract diverse, curious audiences and improves community trust	• Interactive and immersive concert experiences increase overall audience participation • Audiences prefer engaging, multisensory performances over just passively listening	• Traditional Western repertoire limits engagement with local diverse communities. • Programming new works increases inclusivity and artistic relevance to local communities
Insights	BSO should partner with global artists & composers to concerts that represent cultural music	BSO should incorporate visual arts, storytelling, and movement into performances to attract youth	BSO should expand its repertoire to composers with diverse backgrounds reflecting traditions

Review: “National Endowment for the Arts”

Measuring the Impact of Arts and Culture”

	Attendance & Retention	Social and Digital	Educational Program
Observations	• Analyzing ticket sales and audience demographics helps track attendance trends • Returning attendees indicate strong engagement, while low retention suggests gaps	• Monitoring social media shares, comments, and interactions reflects community interest • Increased digital engagement often correlates with stronger in-person attendance for events	• Measuring participation in workshops and youth concerts helps predict future audiences • Early exposure to BSO increases the likelihood of long-term engagement
Insights	Audience retention rates should be segmented by demographics to assess most engaged groups	A strong online presence signals audience interest as and successful outreach efforts	Tracking student participation in education programs can help predict future concert attendance

Review: “SMU DataArts”

KPIs for Nonprofit Arts Organizations



Review: “WolfBrown Research”

Benchmarking Audience Engagement in Performing Arts

	Economic Accessibility	Experiential Engagement	Long Term Engagement
Observations	• Discount ticket program usage can highlight financial barriers to analyze current attendance • Higher participation in affordability programs suggests success in reducing cost barriers	• Post-concert participation in Q&As and discussions measures overall engagement depth • Interactive elements help create lasting emotional connections with all types of audiences	• Comparing first-time attendee conversion rates helps analyze and quantify long-term loyalty • A growing percentage of repeat attendees indicates a sustainable audience base
Insights	Discount programs must be assessed for effectiveness in reaching underrepresented groups	Engagement should be measured beyond attendance, focusing on interaction levels before and after	Long-term audience growth depends on first-time attendance which requires consistent tracking

Review: “Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion in Artistic Planning”

League of American Orchestras – Catalyst Guide

	Programming Strategy	Internal Decision-Making	Community Engagement
Observations	• 2/3 of orchestra programming still centers on older, white, male European composers • BIPOC composers are often included only into themed and heritage month related events	• Most artistic planning tends to be centralized and lacks diverse perspectives and inputs • Orchestras that include EDI advisory groups, report overall increased innovation rates	• Authentic community partners often emerge from co-curated programs, not one-off outreach • Orchestras with artist-led series foster overall long term community musical relevance
Insights	Include diverse curators throughout the season to expand creativity and reduce tokenism	Shift from themed representation to season-wide integration of underrepresented composers	Prioritize co-curation with cultural groups to deepen trust and long-term engagement

Review: “Racial, Ethnic, and Gender Diversity in the Orchestra Field in 2023”

League of American Orchestras – Diversity Report

Musician Representation

Leadership & Conductors

Board & Exec Diversity

Observations

- Black musicians grew only marginally in 10 years: 1.8% (2013) → 2.4% (2023)
- Latinx and Indigenous musicians remain severely underrepresented in the field

- BIPOC conductors now make up about 32%, but generally in assistant or guest roles
- Fewer than 11% of conductors are women, despite gender parity in musician ranks

- Orchestra Executive Boards remain predominantly white and male about 84%
- Smaller budget orchestras are more diverse in staff and programs than larger budget

Insights

Set measurable goals for hiring BIPOC musicians and diversify audition pipelines

Invest in leadership development programs for women and BIPOC conductors and executives

Reform board recruitment to reflect racial and ethnic demographics of local groups

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Review: “EDI Case Studies from American Orchestras”

Steps to successfully creating and maintaining EDI efforts in orchestras

	Transparency	Training	Task Force
Observations	- It is important to prioritize what's doable rather than what seems ideal or better - Progress and plans must be made transparent to internal and external stakeholders	Learning is foundational to change; people cannot identify what they don't understand - Every member of the orchestra must be educated to foster a truly inclusive environment	- A task force with personal commitment will help drive and maintain efforts - Successful task forces are made up of a variety of staff, board, and musicians
Insights	Realistic perspective and transparency to all individuals involved is key to EDI efforts	Training programs are essential to tackling EDI at its roots, changing attitudes and perspectives	BSO should organize a task force that includes the voices of all levels of staff in the orchestra

Review: “Audience Diversification”

Strategies for promoting and measuring audience diversification in orchestras

	Recommendations	Onstage Representation	Prevent Misperception
Observations	• Recommendations from others are much more effective than tooting your own horn • Social media influencers within target communities can draw in young audiences	• Faces of color in orchestra more telling than composers or temporary guest artists • Someone who “looks like me” in a leadership position makes orchestra more welcoming	• People of color thought prices of tickets were much higher than they actually were • Misperceptions about dress codes and access also turned people away from attending
Insights	Collaborate with social media ambassadors to become more visible to younger audiences	Employ a more diverse group of musicians to show people that anyone can be a part of orchestra	Reconsider messaging to ensure proper communication and comfortability with orchestra

Interview with Boston Jazz Foundation



Seba Molnar & Moriah Phillips, Founders of Boston Jazz Foundation

Palatability of Music

Community Partnerships

Post-Covid Practices

Observations

- Jazz seen as being old and outdated rather than **innovative and experimental** like it is
- Seems out of reach to younger generations who separate jazz from **popular, trendy culture**

- Partnered with Berklee Institute of Jazz and Gender Justice, held student performances
- Festival included **tabling** of different organizations, **access to information** about them

- After COVID, less funded communities are not worried art, **not an essential need**
- Dropped prices of tickets or made them free so that **everyone could access art**

Insights

Classical music is also seen as an **old, unreachable**, style of music— tie to **current, relevant culture**

BSO should hold more **extensive partnership** events that **highlight communities** and their missions

BSO **lacks the affordable ticketing programs** needed to address post-covid challenges

Interview with GLAAD

Ross Murray, Vice President of GLAAD Media Institute

	Problematic Progress	Staff Support	Defining Success
Observations	- Problematic progress is common; tired storylines and tropes that feign representation - Need new stories, new perspectives that are true to the experiences of communities	- Help set people working in media up to be helpful allies to the LGBTQ+ community - Train organizations, companies, platforms, individuals on proper inclusivity and integration	GLAAD Media Awards honors media for accurate, inclusive representation of LGBTQ+ Criteria includes impact of project—how it increased dialogue about issues
Insights	BSO needs to make sure their diversity efforts do not box communities into stereotypes	Staff and performers of BSO must also be informed on how to be good representatives and allies	Learn from attempts of other media outlets to define success and failure of BSO's DEI efforts

Interview with Arts Connect International

ARTS CONNECT INTERNATIONAL
BUILDING EQUITY AND INCLUSION IN AND THROUGH THE ARTS



Micah Rose, Co-Director of Emergence of Arts Connect International

	Shared Identities	Cultural Equity	Indigenous Perspective
Observations	- Helpful to have a team made up of those with shared identities with communities - Shared identities make it easier for communities to trust as they feel understood by them	- ACI's Transformative Research Collective includes studies on the cultural equity gap - Focused on perspectives of BIPOC arts leaders and marginalized communities	- ACI working on improving representation of Native artists in the arts space - Furthering collaboration with local tribes in Massachusetts and New England
Insights	Staff those who can easily connect with marginalized communities to build stronger bonds	Identify existing cultural equity gaps in the Boston area to better plan and tailor programming	Explore more heavily underrepresented communities such as native tribes in Boston

Interview with New York Philharmonic



Ugochi Onyeukwu, New York Philharmonic Director of DEI

	Youth Orchestra	Lobby Broadcast	Internal DEI
Observations	• Education program with nine schools around NYC • Trains and sends teaching artists to work at schools • Assembled youth orchestra of students around the city	• Outside David Geffen Hall, events are broadcast in lobby • People who can't afford tickets can still watch events live • Audience is everyone, not just those who buy tickets	• Can't have external DEI without internal alignment • People can feel how authentic the organization is • More important to change the institution, not just the people
Insights	Organize a collective youth orchestra to increase youth engagement and audience	Establish a space at the location of the event for free and accessible viewing of live performances	Before external DEI efforts, first build and establish a welcoming, inclusive internal environment

Interview with the Metropolitan Opera

Melanie Milton, Metropolitan Opera Producer of Public Programming

	Opera Screenings	Successful Strategies	Unique Programming
Observations	• Summer programs designed for community engagement • Screens operas around different boroughs in NYC • HD screenings of opera attract 3-4k people per night	• Successful program - X: The Life and Times of Malcom X • Included his daughter in the program, people who knew him • Intentionally at Metropolitan Opera House, not Harlem	• Contemporary programs that speak on contemporary issues • Next season running a piece on gun violence • Representation of communities with shared experiences
Insights	Hold both recorded and live opera screenings around the Greater Boston area	Include important figures in relevant events, be more intentional about little details	Look to include impacted communities outside of just racial and ethnic groups

Interview with Detroit Symphony Orchestra



Clare Valenti, Director of Engagement of Detroit Symphony Orchestra

	Ethnic Enclaves	Patron Base	Focus Groups
Observations	• Dearborn hosts the largest Arab American population outside of Middle East • DSO trying to increase representation in context of the surrounding suburbs	• Even their free concerts ended up with a lot of the typical patron base in audience • Marketing through emails and promos reaches people whose contact info they already have	• DSO has focus groups of different communities around Detroit and surrounding areas • DSO Neighborhood Initiative emphasizes community-driven processes and planning
Insights	BSO needs to identify any ethnic enclaves within or surrounding Boston to find target audiences	Marketing should target new audiences , not through avenues that reach existing patrons	Sending people to work with specific communities can help to build intimacy and trust

Interview with Chicago Humanities

Chicago
Humanities

Kaity O'Reilly, Programmer

Audience Demographics

Expanding Strategies

Post-Pandemic

Observations

- Audience skews older (48% are in 60s+) and predominately white but younger are diverse
- Partnerships with local orgs bring in diverse groups ie. in Latina and Black neighborhoods

- Nomadic so success depends on collaboration with local orgs to co-create and host events
- Aims to use authentic titles, descriptions, and imagery that reflect event and audience base

- Programming shift from a condensed festival to a more spread-out season events
- Trying out livestreaming events and hybrid programming to reach a broader audience

Insights

Works to engage underrepresented communities by reducing barriers to participation

Attendance patterns have shifted, requiring new marketing and engagement approaches

Cultural engagement depends on partnerships with local orgs vs a top-down approach

Interview with Da Vinci Art Alliance



Samantha Connors, Executive Director of Da Vinci Art Alliance

Language Accessibility

Intergenerational Efforts

Government Grants

Observations

- Neighborhood DVAA is in has a lot of Spanish, Cantonese, Vietnamese speakers
- Trying to navigate **accommodating non-English speaking communities**

- Places heavy emphasis on **intergenerational community building** and events
- Brings **disparate groups** of the community together through a **shared passion** for art

- Uprisings after George Floyd helped **normalize important conversations** arts spaces
- Grants exist now that did not exist before resurgence of BLM during the pandemic

Insights

In its outreach, must include marketing and communications through **other languages**

Hold similar events where **older generations teach younger generations** about orchestra

Look into new grants that would help **fund** certain cultural efforts, **provide better resources**

Interview with Fellowship for Performing Arts

Max McLean, Founder and Artistic Director

	Mission of FPA	Affiliated Communities	Outreach Strategies
Observations	- Mission is to produce theater and arts for Christians based on foundational ideas of religion Engage in ideas of life, death, moral law, creation, morality's origin, before and after-death	- Plays and productions are mostly adapted from CS Lewis' work, so Lewis's enthusiasts - Those who are engaged in Christian faith and interested in FPA's mission on religious faith	Selling tickets online by doing social media marketing, and having a large mailing list Promoting and catering to churches to bring in the key group for their performances
Insights	Have a clear, set mission that your organization sticks to with integration of others	Selecting a central idea/set of materials that can be generalized for a broader audience	Utilizing a large mailing list and being consistent to surpass goal of 50k ticket sold in 2024

Interview with Seattle Symphony

SEATTLE
SYMPHONY

Lorin Green, Seattle Symphony Director of Education & Community Engagement

Consistent Programming

Model Standardization

Community Leadership

Observations

- One-off programs popped up during COVID years, but **failed to remain consistent**
- Spread out, singular events show performative commitment to values, not sustained

- Issue of seeing community engagement as a business model and not a collaboration
- Humanize interactions, learn about the people and what they hope to achieve or gain

- Organizations often force communities to fit into their standards and their vision
- Record sales at Black Panther event advised by members of surrounding black communities

Insights

Rather than offering one-off programs, hold **consistent events** to show **commitment to diversity**

Get rid of business models to truly **connect** with individuals and communities and **build trust**

Let **communities lead initiatives** instead of telling them what the organization thinks they need